
GT DESIGNZ LIMITED

Design & Access Statement

3 Woden Road, Wolverhampton, WV10 0AU

September 2024

GT DESIGNZ LIMITED

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PROPOSAL SUMMARY

The Statement has been prepared in support of a Full Planning Application of 3 Woden Road, Wolverhampton, WV10 0AU from Demolition of side extension, ground floor rear extension and COU to 6 person HMO with associated bins & cycle facilities

SITE AND SURROUNDING AREA

The application site comprises a 2 storey end of terrace dwelling house located on the middle of Woden Road, located in an area comprised of mainly residential and with mixture of a few commercial properties.

The property is located in Wolverhampton. It is not located within any planning constraints.

PLANNING POLICIES

The NPPF

There are no policies dealing specifically with HMOs but para 59 is relevant

" To support the Government's objective of significantly boosting the supply of homes, it is important that a sufficient amount and variety of land can come forward where it is needed, that the needs of groups with specific housing requirements are addressed and that land with permission is developed without unnecessary delay

In this case policies on sustainable transport are also relevant because of the location of the site close to services and employment

"I 02. *Transport issues should be considered from the earliest stages of plan-making and development proposals, so that:*

a) the potential impacts of development on transport networks can be addressed;

b) opportunities from existing or proposed transport infrastructure, and changing transport technology and usage, are realised - for example in relation to the scale, location or density of development that can be accommodated;

c) opportunities to promote walking, cycling and public transport use are identified and pursued;

d) the environmental impacts of traffic and transport infrastructure can be identified, assessed and taken into account - including appropriate opportunities for avoiding and mitigating any adverse effects, and for net environmental gains;

and e) patterns of movement, streets, parking and other transport considerations are integral to the design of schemes, and contribute to making high quality places."

National Guidance on HMOs

Para 2 Guidance on HMOs for local authorities published by MHCLG in October 2019 is supportive of the HMO form of tenure. It says "*Houses in multiple occupation (HMOs) form a vital part of this sector, often providing cheaper accommodation for people whose housing options are limited. HMOs are known to be commonly occupied by students but there are also a growing number of young professionals and migrant workers sharing houses and flats. "*

The Local Plan

The Local Plan also supports the role of HMOS in meeting housing needs

"Policy H9 Ensuring the best use of stock

A) Borough should promote efficient use of existing housing stock to reduce the number of vacant and under-occupied dwellings.

B) The Mayor will support boroughs with identified issues of new homes being left empty, sometimes known as 'buy to leave' properties, to put in place mechanisms which seek to ensure new homes are occupied.

C) Boroughs should take account of the impact on housing stock and local housing need when considering applications for a change of use

D) Boroughs should take account of the role of houses in multiple occupation (HMOs) in meeting local and strategic housing needs. Where they are of a reasonable standard they should generally be protected"

Wolverhampton Council - Houses in Multiple Occupation

1.1. Black Country Core Strategy policy HOU2 requires a range of housing types, tenures and densities to provide choice and create sustainable communities, to meet identified sub-regional and local needs. Furthermore, it requires 'the need to achieve high quality design and minimise amenity impacts, taking into account the characteristics and mix of uses in the area where the proposal is located'.

1.2 Black Country Core Strategy Policy CSP4 (Place-Making) requires a positive contribution to place-making and environmental improvement taking into account: • A high quality of design;

- An appropriate mix of building designs and types which seek to enhance the unique attributes the area offers in terms of its local character and heritage
- Creating safe and secure places by organizing the urban environment that encourage people to act in a civil and responsible manner
- Ensuring an appropriate intensity of use in all areas.

1.3 HMOs are also guided by separate legislation under the Housing Act 2004. This sets out the definition of HMOs and controls the standard and safety of accommodation. Internal requirements for room sizes and cooking/washing facilities are set out in adopted amenity and space standards for licensed and non-licensable HMOs. Whilst these standards are guidance, failure to comply with them, can result in overcrowding notices being served and ultimately prohibition of rooms.

Character and appearance

1.4 The character of the area will be assessed as part of the planning application process to ensure the proposed HMO is acceptable. For example, an area might be characterised by terraced family houses, larger detached properties or have a varied mix of building types and uses. A proposed change may have an unacceptable detrimental impact on the character of the area.

1.5 A proposed HMO should not result in parking dominated frontages or loss of rear garden land. Inadequate garden space, unduly prominent bin storage areas or an intensification of the use resulting in increased comings and goings in a quiet street/area may all have a detrimental impact on the character of an area.

Internal floor areas

1.6 Future residents should benefit from a reasonable internal living space. This Council has adopted amenity and space standards for licensed and non licensable HMOs which provides an objective guide to acceptable standards in terms of room sizes and facilities.

Future residents and neighbours' amenities

1.7 In addition to providing a satisfactory internal living space, future residents should have outdoor amenity space for sitting out, play and drying clothes. Proposed outdoor space will be assessed regarding privacy, quality and usability.

1.8 A proposed HMO should not result in significant loss of privacy for neighbours from overlooking. This could be particularly relevant for upper floor windows, as bedrooms in HMOs tend to be more intensively used than bedrooms in single dwelling houses.

1.9 The number of coming goings (people and vehicles) from a proposed HMO, and general activity around it can greatly increase, causing noise and disturbance for neighbours. Crime and anti-social behaviour

1.10 A proposed HMO should not increase the potential for anti-social behaviour, crime and the fear of crime. Evidence from neighbours and the Police will be taken into account.

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1.16 Paragraphs 91 and 127 of the National Planning Policy Framework recommend that local planning authorities ensure their policies and decisions aim to create safe and accessible environments where crime and disorder, and the fear of crime, do not undermine quality of life or community cohesion. Furthermore, the Police and Justice Act 2006 imposes an obligation on every police authority and local authorities to consider crime and disorder reduction in the exercise of all their duties

1.17 Black Country Core Strategy policy ENV3 (Design Quality) requires development proposals to consider crime prevention. The courts have held that there must be some reasonable evidential basis for the fear of crime and adverse effects to be justified. Police evidence is that crimes are more likely to be committed in HMOs than other tenures in Wolverhampton.

1.18 The Council recognises the importance of continued strong links and a positive working partnership with West Midlands Police in considering planning applications. For all HMO proposals, advice will be sought from West Midlands Police. The Police are in a unique position to assess and predict the likelihood of crime and anti-social behaviour.

1.19 The Council may request sight of a Tenancy Management Scheme to show how tenants would commit to approved standards and practices when living in the HMO and actions the Landlord would take to deal with tenants breaching this. The proposed management regime would need to minimise the opportunity for anti-social behaviour to occur, which may reduce the fear of crime.

Parking and the potential impact on highway safety

1.20 A HMO should not cause significant detriment to pedestrian safety and the safe and free flow of road traffic.

1.21 The National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) seeks to resist development which would have an unacceptable impact on highway safety. it also states that transport policies have an important role to play in facilitating sustainable development and developments should be designed so that journey times are minimised.

1.22 Factors such as whether the site is in a sustainable location, with good access to public transport, or within easy walking and cycling distances of local services, places of education and community facilities will help with the Council's assessment of parking levels required.

1.23 For HMOs in Wolverhampton, 0.5 parking spaces per bedroom provides a general guide for likely demand. This level of provision acknowledges that HMO's tend to attract occupiers with lower-than-average levels of car ownership compared to the general population. It also provides a basis on which to compare the parking demand between the existing dwelling and the proposed HMO. However, parking demand will vary depending on location and property, so careful judgement is required on a case by case basis.

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1.28 In areas where houses rely on on-street parking only, the Council will determine whether the proposed use will generate a greater parking demand or vehicle trips than the existing house. Where it would significantly add to congestion, there should be off-street parking provided or the proposal is likely to be refused.

1.29 Tandem off-street parking bays are not acceptable for HMOs, as they can be difficult to manage for occupants who are unrelated. Bays could be underutilised and result in additional on-street parking.

1.30 The provision of off-street parking may result in the replacement of traditional front gardens with open hard standing and the removal of front and side boundary walls, these elements often add to local distinctiveness. This often creates a negative impact on the existing character of the street and, in some cases localised flooding, and will, therefore, be resisted.

1.31 Detriment can be caused by off-street parking areas in rear gardens of properties. This increases noise disturbance to adjacent neighbours, who can expect a more tranquil environment in private amenity areas.

1.33 The provision of secure cycle parking for residents is encouraged.

Bin storage

1.34 HMOs should provide make acceptable provision for bin storage that will not harm the character of the area or residential amenities.

Licensable HMO's

With effect from the 1st October 2018, all HMO's having 5 or more occupants in 2 or more households require to be licensed by the Council. Prior to the 1st October 2018, only HMO's of 3 or more storeys and having 5 or more occupants require a licence, but applications for those HMO's which will become licensable on the 1st October are being accepted and processed. In these cases, the licence will commence on the 1st October 2018.

Space and amenity standards Wolverhampton City Council has adopted space and amenity standards for Houses in Multiple Occupation occupied as bedsits, self-contained flats and shared housing. Most of the accommodation arrangements commonly encountered are described, however it is recognised that there will always be circumstances which do not match those given. If this is the case then it will always be advisable to contact the Private Sector Housing Team for further guidance. Further, before any conversion, adaption and/or new build, advice must be sought from our Planning and Building Control Sections.

Shared houses type accommodation space standards

Houses occupied on a shared basis, these would normally be occupied by members of a defined social group e.g. students. The occupiers each enjoy exclusive use of a bedroom but would share other facilities including a communal living room.

One person units of accommodation		
<i>Each bedroom/study</i>	<i>10m²</i>	<i>Except where a separate living room is provided which is not a kitchen or kitchen/dining room in which case the bedroom shall be 6.51m²</i>
Two person units of accommodation		
	<i>15m²</i>	<i>Except where a separate living room is provided which is not a kitchen or kitchen/dining room, in which case the bedroom shall be 11m²</i>
Kitchens		
<i>Used by 1-3 persons</i>	<i>5m²</i>	
<i>Used by 4 person</i>	<i>6m²</i>	
<i>Used by 5 persons</i>	<i>7m²</i>	
<i>For each person above 5</i>	<i>Add 1m² per person</i>	
Dining/kitchens		
<i>Used by 2-5 persons</i>	<i>11.5m²</i>	
<i>Used by 6-10 persons</i>	<i>19.5m²</i>	
Living rooms and dining rooms		
<i>Used by 2-5 persons</i>	<i>11m²</i>	
<i>Used by 6-10 persons</i>	<i>16.5m²</i>	

Washing and toilet facilities for bedsit and shared accommodation

A readily accessible bath or shower room and toilet shall be provided not more than one floor distant from any intended user. The walls and floor of any bath or shower room and toilet should be reasonably smooth and non-absorbent and capable of being easily cleansed and the rooms of adequate size and layout.

Every room containing a toilet must be provided with a wash hand basin.

All baths, showers and wash hand basins must be equipped with taps providing an adequate supply of cold and constant hot water.

All bathrooms and shower rooms must be suitably and adequately heated and ventilated.

***4 or fewer** occupiers sharing facilities, there must be at least one bathroom with a fixed bath or shower and a toilet with wash hand basin (which may be situated in the bathroom)*

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***5** occupiers, one **separate** toilet with wash hand basin, one bathroom with a fixed bath or shower (the separate toilet may be located in a second bathroom).*

***6-10** occupiers, 2 bathrooms containing a bath or shower and 2 toilets with wash hand basins, one of which must be in a separate room.*

***11-15** occupiers, 3 bathrooms containing a bath or shower and 3 toilets with wash hand basins, one of which must be in a separate room.*

Kitchen facilities for bedsit and shared accommodation

Each occupancy shall have constant access to a shared kitchen no more than one floor distant from the large majority of users, unless provided within the unit of accommodation. It is acceptable however, for a kitchen to be a maximum of two floors distant where there is a communal dining room adjacent to the kitchen or where the kitchen is of sufficient size to serve as a kitchen/dining room.

For every 5 occupants there needs to be a complete set of kitchen facilities. However, for one additional person i.e. 6 persons, rather than put in a complete set of facilities a combination microwave oven and grill may be substituted in place of a conventional cooker and an electric dishwasher or half bowl in place of a standard sink. There should be no more than two sets of facilities in any one room.

The facilities shall comprise where shared and where located within a bedsit,

- A gas or electric cooker with minimum four burners/hobs, oven and a grill (where cooking provided within a bedsit and only used by 1 person, two burners/hobs oven and grill is acceptable). Table top portable cooking facilities are not acceptable.*
- A metal or ceramic kitchen sink and drainer with a constant supply of hot and cold water.*
- Sufficient fixed work surface to enable each user to prepare food safely and hygienically. A minimum of 500mm depth and length clear run of work surface per person will generally be sufficient for this purpose although minor variations may be acceptable where there is still a good practical working area.*
- A refrigerator of sufficient size to store an average persons dietary requirements on a day to day basis.*
- Sufficient storage cupboard space for dry and canned foods and sufficient storage for cooking utensils, crockery and cutlery.*
- Two twin outlet power sockets in addition to any serving major appliances set at a convenient height and safe position.*
- The kitchen area must be provided with an easily cleansable non-slip floor covering to an adequate extent and separated from any adjoining carpeted area by suitable dividing strips securely fixed in position.*

ASSESSMENT

Principle of Development

The proposal would be demolition of side extension, ground floor rear extension and COU to 6 person HMO with associated bins & cycle facilities.

The current proposal will include 6 bedrooms with ensuites. The current proposal consists of a good size kitchen and dining area.

The site is located near center of Wolverhampton with many shops nearby. Wolverhampton train station and tram are near the site. Therefore, any potential workers will have access to effective public transfers to travel to and from work from the site.

Bentley Bridge Leisure Park is only 1 mile away and 5 minutes' drive away. Asda Supermarket is only 0.6 miles away and 10 minutes' walk away from the site.

New Cross Hospital, Wolverhampton and Urgent care is only 0.9 miles away from the site, with high level of accommodation of this type required for working individual or visiting family of patients required to stay the night.

Given the site location and the potential use as a HMO, the number of residents occupying is 6 person which would not cause harm to the character of the area and the amenities of the neighboring properties therefore. The residents will be screened carefully before renting the rooms

HMO Demand:

There has been strong demand for HMO properties for students, young professionals and young couples. Overall, this growing demand is expected to continue in the coming years as younger people are becoming more accustomed to co-living. The average age of renters has even been on the rise, meaning tenants are renting for longer than previous generations.

Across the UK, we still aren't anywhere near our targets for building new homes. There has been a housing shortage, and this is expected to continue for at least the next 5 to 10 years. In 2019 /20, the total housing stock in England grew by 244,000 homes, according to government data. This is

approximately 1% more than the year before. Current estimates show the number of new homes needed in England is 345,000 a year.

The supply of housing has been growing in recent years, but it's still lower than what is needed. The government has set a goal of creating 300,000 new homes a year by the mid-2020s. However, many have said this is unlikely to be achieved at the current rates of growth in the homebuilding industry.

These figures further show the continued need for more housing to be brought forward. And HMO properties are one of the areas where we can create new rental units. This can help alleviate pressure due to the housing shortage, and it provides an opportunity to bring forward high-quality housing.

Affordability is definitely a big factor for them, as the cost of renting a room in a shared house will almost always be less expensive than renting an entire property (even a 1 bedroom flat) on their own.

Most of the HMOs we're aware of include the bills in the cost of the rent (council tax, utility bills, WiFi, and even regular cleaning of communal areas), so as an overall package, it's difficult to beat.

HMOs provide opportunities for social interaction and community-building among tenants. Shared living spaces, such as communal kitchens and living rooms, provide a space for tenants to connect with each other, which can be particularly important for students and young professionals who are new to an area.

In summary, HMO properties can be a valuable addition to the rental market, providing affordable housing options, flexibility, opportunities for social interaction, efficient use of space, and diversification of the rental market.

HMO Management

HMO Property Licensing specialise in property management, they have a tailored proactive approach and offer the right services to suit the needs of the tenants.

Through the years, they are able to offer a hassle-free service. The bespoke management service consists of marketing the property, vetting suitable tenants, maintaining the property in the most cost-efficient way and approving a monthly breakdown summary statement. With this service, there is peace of mind the property is fully compliant and correctly maintained in line with local authority regulations.

Their criteria for selecting good tenants is thorough and in the unlikely event of receiving complaints from neighboring properties, they are capable of establishing good relationships ensuring the situation is handled professionally.

Wolverhampton Council - Houses in Multiple Occupation

Black Country Core Strategy policy HOU2 requires a range of housing types, tenures and densities to provide choice and create sustainable communities, to meet identified sub-regional and local needs. Furthermore, it requires 'the need to achieve high quality design and minimise amenity impacts, taking into account the characteristics and mix of uses in the area where the proposal is located'.

Black Country Core Strategy Policy CSP4 (Place-Making) requires a positive contribution to place-making and environmental improvement taking into account:

- A high quality of design;

- An appropriate mix of building designs and types which seek to enhance the unique attributes the area offers in terms of its local character and heritage
- Creating safe and secure places by organizing the urban environment that encourage people to act in a civil and responsible manner
- Ensuring an appropriate intensity of use in all areas.

With reference to the HMO SPD 2022, 4.3 BH7, states that HMO applications will be supported when meeting the criteria set out, the application site meets the requirements as it is:

PTAL 3, with access to local parade of shops within a few minutes' walk.

- Provision of a rear garden that can be accessed from two rooms on the ground floor and side gate, 158m² is ample space for the residents.
- Provision of waste and recycle wheelie bins as indicated on the plans to serve the residents.
- The rooms have had continuous rent and are still in use, good access to public transport allows the residents to get to their workplaces.

Public Transport

Wolverhampton Train station is an 20 Minute walk from the application site, access to busses is available from the corner to Woden Road on Cannock Road within a very short walking distance. Buses available are 2,11,70 & 793.

Living Standards

The proposed HMO has 6 bedrooms for single occupancy with ensuite. All bedrooms have good means of outlook and ventilation. Therefore the proposed spaces comply with Wolverhampton's Council's HMO standards as demonstrated in the floor plans. Communal kitchen/dining facilities have been provided in accordance with HMO SPD - Kitchen Space.

Car Parking

There is no need for the cars to be parked on the site. As the site has the benefit for very good public transport. With the best stops just round the corner of the site. Nearby Supermarkets, train station and Hospitals are a walking distance.

Cycle Parking

The proposal is also looking to provide 6 cycle parking spaces at the rear of the property accessed via the side entrance seen on the floor plans.

Waste

The provision is no different to the majority of other properties in the local area. Bins are located to the front of the properties and wheeled out on collection day. Collection times and procedures would state how the tenants are to ensure the property is kept clean, tidy and smell free. Refuse storage would ensure that waste and recyclables can be emptied regularly in accordance with the management plan. Residents would be responsible to place bags out on collection.

Internal Layout

The accommodation is on the ground and first and second floor of the property. The dining space is can facilitate up to 6 occupants and within guidelines set on Wolverhampton HMO.

The proposed plans show 6 rooms containing single beds which can accommodate 1 occupants. There were will few internal changes to the floor plans.

The house size and layout of the existing property does comply with SPD guidelines as it is able to accommodate 6 occupants.

The refuse located to the front of the site will provide continuity of the street scene to allow the property to blend with the local vernacular as being an ordinary property.

There are no harmful affects to the surrounding neighboring properties, nor their amenities as demonstrated by no complaints raised historically.

The property itself has ample amount of space to occupy 6 adults.

Therefore, this planning application will bear no harmful impact to the tenants residing at the property either nor to the neighboring properties.

SHARED INDOOR AMENITY SPACE

As referenced in the Wolverhampton HMO SPD - Shared indoor amenity space provides adequate space that more than meets the requirements for a 6 person HMO.

LAUNDRY FACILITIES

The washing machine and dryer are provided in the existing kitchen space.

CONCLUSION

The property shall be managed by an experienced agency specializing in HMO properties and the tenants are carefully selected to ensure no nuisance occurs, thus it is expected that the HMO would provide a safe and social environment for its future occupiers.

The proposed room sizes are of generous space and provide quality accommodation not only meeting HMO standards but also a new purpose-built accommodation of this nature. Hence the proposed 6 occupiers within this property will not harm the character, amenities, and neighboring properties of the area and it would provide the much-needed affordable accommodation.